



Tech-Com SSD-645K
Pricy underdog

MID-RANGE WEBCAMS

The Rs 801 to Rs 1,700 price range is where most consumers gravitate to. Clarity and sharpness at lower-resolution images / streams is the deciding factor when it comes to competition.

Nine webcams made it to this category, from five brands Logitech sent in four; Zebronic, two.

Features

The basic feature set here remains the same as in the previous category, but these are better built and designed.

Night Vision

The Zebronic 1300 WC implements a pop-open top that hides three LEDs for better performance in low-light conditions, and also a dual-lens design: one for short distances and other for long

distances (30 to 150 m). The provision by Zebronic of a manual rotor to control the intensity of the night vision LED's is noteworthy.

The Clamp

The Genius Look 312P uses a flexible frame structure; yet it tends to fall off. The clamping mechanism implemented by Logitech is the best, and poses the least problem in clamping onto LCDs. Microsoft's foldable clamp is one of the better-designed ones, but this poses problems in clamping to thicker LCD bezels. The clamps on the Zebronic aren't wide enough to clamp onto LCDs with thicker bezels.

The Snapshot Button

The Logitech QuickCam series is studded with a snapshot switch on the camera. The provision of snapshot switch on the USB cord by Zebronic on its 1300 WC is a more practical approach; it minimises the chances of the webcam shaking while taking a snap. The Microsoft VX-1000 implements a similar button, but this is used instead for making calls using Windows Live! Messenger.

Accessories

Logitech's drivers support Vista. The software bundled with the HP PhotoSmart and the QuickCam V10 is feature-rich. Vista is also supported by the Microsoft VX-1000's drivers. The software bundled with the LifeCam 1.2 has only a basic feature set—albeit with a quick, easy-to-navigate interface. The Genius also has Vista support, but the DD PlayCam 2 software is buggy in terms of navigation. The Look 312P from Genius is supported in Linux, unlike the others.

Aesthetics And Build Quality

The puppy-shaped Genius Look 312P is the most attractive of the lot. The Microsoft VX-1000 sports good build quality with a small, foldable clamp that makes it easy to install on

How We Tested

The *Digit* Printer test image was used as the subject in this webcam test. It was set 60 cm in front of the webcams under test. All the webcams were then evaluated on the basis of three basic parameters—Features, Performance, and Price. These basic parameters are given relevant weightages based on the importance each parameter plays in its category. The three parameters put together contribute to whether a product gets awarded the *Digit Best Buy Gold* and *Digit Best Buy Silver* for each category.

Features

The feature sets of the webcams were looked at according to category, and points were awarded on the basis of the part the feature plays in terms of usability and the buyer's application. Features looked at included whether there is automatic, manual, or fixed focus. We also checked for zoom, audio capture, a separate headset / microphone, a snapshot button, swivel, whether it is motor-driven, length of the cable and whether it is detachable, a provided stand and a clamp for fixing the webcam to LCD panels (some feature we expect only on high-end webcams). We also checked the quality of each of these components.

Bundled software, their usefulness, ease of use, and support for different operating systems was also noted. So were extra features such as face tracking, and noise cancellation. In addition, the sturdiness of the webcam, its stability, and aesthetic appeal were also awarded points.

Performance

The tests were performed under both fluorescent lighting and daylight conditions. The test for daylight conditions was conducted indoors with a large window open to allow natural light to enter the test area. We noted image capture quality and colour reproduction compared to the original *Digit* Printer test image, and the amount of brightness and detail.

The fluorescent lighting condition test is more important, because most people use webcams indoors. The testing area was lit up with a tubelight and note was made of the quality of image capture. We rated the captured image quality. Performance in the dark was gauged on both the regular as well as night-vision-enabled webcams.

A scale of 10 was used in both cases (daylight and fluorescent) to rate sub-parameters like colour reproduction and image brightness, contrast, and sharpness.